CAUGHT IN A QUAGMIRE

Faced by a resurgent Congress and radicals, the AAP finds itself in a precarious place

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**



BHAGWANT MANN
Chief Minister, Punjab

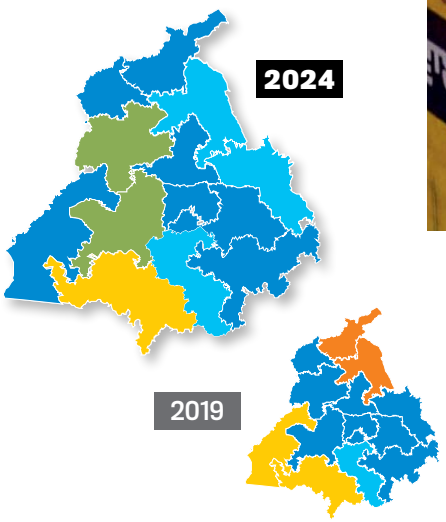
PTI

For the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), embattled as it is with its convenor Arvind Kejriwal back in jail, the news from Punjab would have been of little solace. In a virtual mid-term referendum on the Bhagwant Mann regime's performance, the party managed to win just three of the 13 Lok Sabha seats in the border state, its vote share plummeting to 26.3 per cent from the 42 per cent it had cornered in the assembly election just over two years ago.

The AAP, in a seat-sharing agreement with the Congress elsewhere, decided to go solo in Punjab. And it was Mann who took it upon himself to lead the party's campaign, holding 122 public rallies and roadshows over 25 days besides travelling to Delhi and other states to canvass for the AAP candidates. Now, it seems, his campaign, built around the slogan '*Sansad vich vi Bhagwant Mann* (Mann in Parliament too)', failed to stir the voters to the extent he had expected.

Mann had conquered the state with 92 seats in the 117-member assembly in 2022. It goes to his credit that the AAP was also able to increase its Lok Sabha tally to three from the one seat it secured in 2019. But his party candidates led in only 27 assembly segments. In comparison, the Congress dominated in 40 segments, translating into its win in seven Lok Sabha seats.

Meanwhile, the traditional custodians of Panthic voters, the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), slipped further down to a lone seat—Harsimrat Badal from the family bastion Bathinda—and a meagre 13.4 per cent vote share, and the radicals garnered significant support. Fighting as Independents, jailed Khalistan propagandist Amritpal Singh (Khadoor Sahib) and Sarabjit Singh Khalsa (Faridkot), the son of former prime minister Indira Gandhi's assassin Beant Singh, won by massive margins, reigniting concerns over the resurgence of the separatist movement and the radicalisation of Sikh youth.



TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 13

	CONG	AAP	SAD	BJP
2024	7 (26.3%)	3 (26%)	1 (13.4%)	0 (18.6%)
2019	8 (40.1%)	1 (7.4%)	2 (27.4%)	2 (9.6%)

Independents

Vote share in ( )

So, it comes as no surprise that Punjabi Hindus seem to have gravitated towards the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in urban centres like Patiala, Ludhiana, Jalandhar and Amritsar. Despite drawing a blank, the saffron party led in 24 assembly segments and secured an impressive vote share of 18.6 per cent, up from 6.6 per cent in the 2022 assembly election. Back then, AAP had dominated all these segments.

Mann's grand strategy of fielding five cabinet ministers failed to yield the desired results. Among them, only Gurmeet Singh Meet Hayer emerged victorious, regaining Mann's old parliamentary constituency Sangrur. Meanwhile, Opposition leader Partap Singh Bajwa, who was against an alliance with the AAP and spearheaded the Congress campaign, has effectively positioned himself as a formidable challenger to Mann.

With factionalism brewing within the party's state unit, Mann faces the daunting task of regaining control of the party and trust of the electorate, especially with its legislators being accused of high-handedness and the CM failing to revitalise the state's finances. The next electoral battle in Punjab will be the bypolls in five assembly seats—a litmus test for both Mann's and the AAP's resilience. ■